REP-015 · Art direction: what "It Takes Two" can teach a 2D phone game

Game	Fruit Market
Report date	2026-10-26 23:18 (Asia/Kuala_Lumpur)
Owner input	Bothers most: (a) clutter, (c) lack of animation and feel, (d) the art style itself. Polished reference: *It Takes Two*
Type	Creative direction options and a revised plan. **No game changes.**
Approval status	DEC-021 and the revised PLAN-008 **awaiting approval**; PLAN-007 still awaiting approval

1 · What this changes

REP-014 started with fixing broken-looking details. Your answer puts the priority elsewhere: **the art style, the feel, and the clutter**. That's a bigger and more important decision, so it should be designed and tested before anything is built.

2 · What makes *It Takes Two* feel polished (the qualities we can borrow)

It Takes Two (Hazelight, 2021) is a 3D console game, so we can't copy its look or technology, and we must not reuse any of its art or characters. Its polish comes from qualities that translate to 2D:

Quality	In *It Takes Two*	What it could mean for Fruit Market
Toy-like, touchable materials	The world is shrunk to toy size: wood, felt, clay, fabric	Stalls of painted wood, fruit like shiny clay or wooden toys, cloth awnings, chalkboard price tags
Chunky, rounded shapes	Soft silhouettes, big heads, readable at a glance	Rounder cards and buttons, bigger and simpler characters, fewer thin lines
Warm light and depth	Soft shadows, glow, layers of foreground and background	Gentle drop shadows, a warm late-afternoon harbour backdrop, depth between the table and the cards
Everything reacts	Squash and stretch, bounces, particles on every action	Fruit hops into your basket, coins bounce, buttons squish, the price reveal *flips*
Expressive characters	Faces and poses show feeling all the time	Customers smile, frown or shrug at the reveal; rivals react with a pose, not just a text line
One thing to look at	The camera always frames the important moment	Each phase zooms into what matters (market, customers, reveal) and dims the rest

3 · Three art directions (choose one)

	A · Polished pixel	**B · Toy-box tabletop (recommended)**	**C · 3D toy diorama**
Idea	Keep pixel art; make it consistent and animated	A smooth 2D illustrated style: toy-like, rounded, warm, with soft shadows and textures	Real 3D: a miniature market you look down on

	A · Polished pixel	B · Toy-box tabletop (recommended)	C · 3D toy diorama
Fixes your (d) art style?	**Weakly**: same look, just cleaner	**Yes**: a clearly new, warmer, toy-like look	Yes, and closest to the reference
Fixes (c) feel	Partly	Yes: built around motion from the start	Yes
Phone speed	Excellent	Good (vector art; we keep the speed budget)	Risky on cheap phones; heavier download
Scope	Small	Medium-large: redraw fruits, ~30 characters, rivals, ~40 icons, UI	Very large: a new rendering engine and 3D models
Who makes the art	Claude, in code (as now)	Claude, in code as vector art (consistent, revisable), **or** a hired illustrator later	3D modelling is beyond what Claude can do well; it needs an artist (paid)
Cost	RM0	RM0 if Claude draws it; an illustrator would be a separate paid decision	Paid artist plus large engineering
Risk	Doesn't satisfy (d)	Art quality by Claude is good but not AAA; judge it on the style test before committing	Highest cost, slowest; could stall the game

Recommendation: B, proven by a small style test first. It addresses all three of your concerns, stays fast on phones, costs nothing if I draw it, and can be judged before any real work. If the test looks too plain, the next step would be to brief a paid illustrator. That would be a separate, priced decision under your RM500/month ceiling.

4 · Revised PLAN-008 · Style test plus layout mockups (design only, no game code)

1. **Style test:** the *same* buying screen drawn three ways (A, B, C as a flat render), plus one fruit at its four freshness stages, one customer and one rival in direction B. It's a page you open on your phone.
2. **Layout mockups in the chosen direction** for buy, price, reveal, evening and home, with:
   - the clutter fixes from REP-014 (one top bar, slim rival stalls, demand in plain words)
   - one focus per phase
   - motion notes (what moves, when) and a short animated example of the reveal flip
3. **Your choice:** you pick the direction and the layout options. Only then do I propose the build plan(s).

Acceptance: M1, a phone-viewable page with the style test (3 directions on one screen) and the 5 mockup screens. M2, every idea is linked to a problem in REP-014 or a quality in section 2. M3, no game code changed. All art is original; reference games are inspiration only.

5 · Where PLAN-007 (the 9 broken-looking fixes) fits now

You didn't pick (b), and a new art style would redraw most of those screens anyway. Two options:

- **Keep it small (recommended):** do only the fixes that survive any art change. That's the grammar ("You offers"), the money pop going off-screen, and the sales text being cut off. Ship them in 1.1.2 with Patches; park the rest until the new style.
- Or drop PLAN-007 entirely and fold everything into the new design.

6 · Order of work

1. Publish 1.1.1 (your Deploy) and run the first playtest on the current look (baseline).
2. PLAN-008 style test, then you choose a direction.
3. Layout mockups in that direction, then you choose.
4. A build plan for the new look and feel (likely several packages), released as **1.2.0**, then a second playtest.

7 · Questions (max 3)

1. **Approve the revised PLAN-008** (style test plus mockups, no game code)?
2. **PLAN-007:** keep it small (3 fixes in 1.1.2) or drop it?
3. **Is a paid illustrator possible later,** if the B style test isn't good enough? A yes or no now helps me plan; any spending would still need its own quote and approval.

8 · Decisions

ID	Question	Recommendation	Status
DEC-021	Art direction for the polish	Explore A/B/C in a style test; recommend B (toy-box tabletop)	Awaiting approval
PLAN-008 (revised)	Style test plus layout mockups, design only	Approve	Awaiting approval
PLAN-007	Broken-looking fixes	Reduce to 3 fixes that survive any art change	Awaiting your choice